

Road to Riyadh: India gears up for Esports challenge

India has **confirmed** its coaches for the Esports Nations Cup, while S8UL from the country finalised its rosters for the Esports World Cup.

Neeladri Bhattacharjee
neeladri.b@thehindu.co.in

There is a peculiar kind of quiet before a revolution, and in India's gaming dens, hostels, and late-night Discord calls, that lull has just been broken.

The Esports Nations Cup — an ambitious invention that dares to ask whether ones and zeroes can stir national pride will debut in Riyadh from November 2 to 29, 2026. And India has named its coaches to lead the charge.

Nine generals, nine titles, one singular task: find players, build strategies, and steer a country onto the global stage.

Moin Ejaz (**in pic**), aka "NO_Chanc3", who famously guided India to a bronze medal at the Commonwealth Esports Championships in Birmingham, will handle Dota 2. For Battlegrounds Mobile India, Rahul — 'Ayogi' to his followers — arrives with a CV heavy on silverware: the BGMI Pro Series, the Masters Series, the Chennai Global Championship, and BGIS 2026.

He has guided Blind Esports and Team SouL to glory.

Abhishek Bajaj, or GodspeedxD, takes VALORANT after winning titles with Reckoning Esports and Bleed Esports. Pankaj Upadhyay, KAKA to the faithful, will oversee League of Legends.

For MOBA Legends, India has looked abroad: the Filipino Steve 'Dale' Vitug, twice guided teams to top-six finishes at the World Championship. Pratik Mehra, known for his stint with Fnatic, where he led the team to a win at PUBG Mobile All Stars India 2019, will handle PUBG: Battlegrounds.

Ashrit Goyal (notyAshritB) takes Rainbow Six Siege after a runner-up finish at South Asia Nationals. Nirjhar

Mitra (jocse) will steer Rocket League, having already represented India at the Asian Nations Cup qualifiers. And from Indonesia comes Gradyano Valendy, a man with a name that belongs on a grand prix entry list, to coach Honor of Kings.

They are part of a global army: more than 700 coaches across 100 nations, appointed by the Esports Foundation. The full 16-game line-up for ENC 2026 includes everything from Apex Legends to Chess, from Counter-Strike to Trackmania. More than 100,000 players will contest hundreds of qualifiers. The prize pool stands at 20 million, with equal pay per player and coach—50,000 for first place, 30,000 for second, 15,000 for third.

But India's ambitions do not begin and end with the ENC. S8UL has simultaneously unveiled its complete line-up for the Esports World Cup 2026 — a separate, club-based colossus in Riyadh running from July 6 to August 23, with a staggering \$75 million prize pool.

S8UL will field teams across 12 titles, blending internationals with homegrown talent. The BGMI roster reads like a roll call of Indian excellence: Thunder, Goblin, Jokerr, NakuL, LEGIT.

In Chess, it has Aravindh Chithambaram and Nihal Sarin. In EA Sports FC, it has recruited across borders: an Indian, a German, and a Frenchman. Fighting games see Ansh Arora and Prateek Bhaunt carrying the flag in Street Fighter 6 and Fatal Fury.

Two tournaments, two timelines, one Riyadh summer and autumn, and nine Indian coaches — one that will define another chapter of the esports revolution in the country.